



Reframe Prompts

Move from a stressful thought to a more balanced, usable next step

Examine a stressful thought with honesty and compassion, then choose one action within your control.

Reframe Prompts

Teens and adults

Balanced is not the same as positive

The point is not to convince yourself that everything is fine. The point is to separate facts from predictions, make room for context, and decide what action is possible now.

How to use this tool

Work through the pages in any order. Use a pen, pencil, or digital annotation tool. Keep what helps; leave what does not.

Important

Reframing should never minimize trauma, abuse, grief, discrimination, or real danger. Prioritize immediate safety and qualified support when circumstances are serious or thoughts feel uncontrollable. If you may be in immediate danger or cannot stay safe, contact emergency services or an appropriate crisis resource now.

Thought snapshot

Write the thought as it appeared. Then slow it down.

The exact thought

When it showed up

Feeling or urge that followed

What is observable fact?

What is interpretation, prediction, or self-judgment?

Evidence and alternative lenses

Evidence that supports the thought

Write only facts, not fears.

Evidence that complicates it

What facts, exceptions, or missing information matter?

Kind friend lens

What would I say honestly to someone I care about?

Practical lens

What is the next useful step even if the thought is partly true?

My control circle

I can control

my next action, my words, my schedule, asking for help

I can influence

a conversation, preparation, a request, a boundary

I cannot control

other people's choices, the past, every outcome

My balanced statement

Use both sides of the situation.

This is difficult, and...

I may not be able to..., but I can...

The next small action I will take is...

When I will take it

Sources and use note

This printable tool was designed with general self-care and coping concepts from the sources below. It is educational material, not health care or therapy.

National Institute of Mental Health: Caring for Your Mental Health

Self-care, connection, stress-management framing

<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/topics/caring-for-your-mental-health>

National Institute of Mental Health: So Stressed Out

Journaling, relaxation, mindfulness, sleep, and support concepts

<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/publications/so-stressed-out-fact-sheet>

NHS: Breathing exercises for stress

Comfortable, unforced breathing guidance

<https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/self-help/guides-tools-and-activities/breathing-exercises-for-stress/>

WebMD: What Is Box Breathing?

Optional paced-breathing presentation

<https://www.webmd.com/balance/what-is-box-breathing>

WebMD: Quick Stress-Relief Rituals

Sensory grounding context

<https://www.webmd.com/depression/quick-stress-relief-rituals>

American Psychological Association: Stress management tips

Thought, emotion, behavior, and reframing context

<https://www.apa.org/topics/stress/tips>

CASEL: Fundamentals of SEL

Emotion identification and self-management framing

<https://casel.org/fundamentals-of-sel/>

CDC: Information for Family Caregivers

Caregiver capacity, breaks, and support framing

<https://www.cdc.gov/disability-and-health/about/information-for-family-caregivers.html>

Child Mind Institute: How to Help Children Calm Down

Coping-ahead and child-friendly calming support

<https://childmind.org/article/how-to-help-children-calm-down/>

Wikipedia: Mindfulness

Plain-language background only; not clinical authority

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mindfulness>

Reddit community discussions

User-centered presentation inspiration only; not clinical authority

https://www.reddit.com/r/Anxiety/comments/1ch67c8/making_an_anxiety_tool_box_what_should_i_put_in_it/

YouTube guided box-breathing example

Visual pacing inspiration only; not clinical authority

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tEmt1Znux58>